

CAKE conf 2026

Copy that, words we didn't choose

Justin Gagne, Senior UX Writer at Apify

Thinking...

Fathoming...

Musing...

Crystallizing...

Polishing...

Thinking... fathoming... musing... crystallizing... polishing... leveraging... streamlining... unpacking...
move the needle... circle back... at the end of the day...

Who writes like this?

Close your eyes

Picture a flywheel

When's the last time you touched one, used one, or even saw one?

This is my flywheel...



VariType Headliner 820, circa 1966. It set headlines from 12 to 90 points using interchangeable font discs. [Prepressure](#)

And this is a flywheel...



Vintage Landini tractor with a large exposed metal flywheel. [Wikipedia](#)

Oh, it's a business metaphor, too?

We all have a context window. Mine is clearly type-centric.

Let's start with a concrete example...



Hotel Forum, Kraków. Construction: 1978–88. Photo by Błażej Pindor, 2003. [WhiteMAD](#), 2024

Another ~~concrete~~ example

An example is already concrete. *That's why it's an example.* 🙌

Copy that, words we didn't choose

That's what I want to talk about.

The words that arrive before we remember choosing them.

Dzień dobry, hej, hello

I'm Justin Gagne.

I'm a UX writer, designer, builder, and educator. I'm a content-first club member.

I believe writing is designing, and I notice words like a designer spots bad kerning.

Once you see it, you can't stop. I appreciate well-written copy. I see you (thank you).

Dzień dobry, hej, hello

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About that flywheel...

- A colleague said “flywheel” in a meeting.
- Someone else said it at an offsite.
- A presenter I’d never met said it in a webinar.

Suddenly, a machine part was load-bearing vocabulary in three conversations.

Load-bearing vocabulary

Did any of us choose it?

You speak like where you work

Aquent: **wheelhouse**. Apify: **flywheel**.

Both borrowed from machines. Both arrived with the job.

You write like what you read

How the model behaves is really a function of what kind of things it was exposed to.

— Sean Goedecke (GitHub), [Why AI loves em dashes, with Sean Goedecke](#), *Grammar Girl*, 2026

Models write like what they're exposed to

So do we.

We didn't learn to sound like this from the robots

They learned it from us.

We learned what professional writing sounded like...

Documentation

- The changes were saved successfully
- The user is required to sign in
- The request cannot be processed at this time

But the context changed

There was a person on the other side.

Now we're talking to someone

- Your changes are saved
- Sign in to continue
- Something went wrong. Try again.

tl;dr (too long; didn't read)

We share what we haven't read.

The models read everything

Do we?

You write like what you read

What happens when we don't?

What does the reader see?

An LLM paragraph will register to much of your audience not as writing but as output.

— *A Final Word*, 2026

Sometimes we don't read because we don't have to

We skim. We scan. We skip.

Tag soup

HTML + JavaScript + server-side code + HTML + JavaScript + ...

```

<% c = 1 -%>
<% f = 1 -%>
<% for page in @pages -%>
  <tr class="<% if !page.is_active %>inactive <% end %><%= (c%2 == 0 ? 'alt_row'
  ' : '') %><%= (f == 1 ? 'first_row' : '') %>">
    <td class="first_col"><%= page.created_at.strftime('%d %b, %Y') %></td>
    <td><%= link_to (page.title == '' ? '[Untitled]' : page.title),
Site.full_url + '/admin/pages/edit/' + page.id.to_s %></td>
    <td><%= truncate(Post.strip_html(page.body), 50) %></td>
    <td><%= page.permalink %></td>
    <td class="del_col"><%= link_to 'X', Site.full_url +
'/admin/pages/destroy/' + page.id.to_s, :confirm => "You are about to delete
this page. This is permanent.\n\nAre you ABSOLUTELY sure?" %></td>
  </tr>
  <% c = (c == 1 ? c+1 : c = 1) -%>
  <% f = f+1 -%>
<% end -%>
<% unless @pages.length > 0 -%>
<tr class="first_row"><td class="first_col" colspan="5"><span
class="gray">There are no pages at this time.</span></td></tr>
<% end -%>
<% if @page_pages %>
<tr class="header">
  <th colspan="5">
    <div class="pagination">
      <div class="prev">
        <%= link_to '&laquo; Previous page', { :sort => params[:sort], :page =>
@page_pages.current.previous } if @page_pages.current.previous %>
        &nbsp;</div>
        <div class="next">&nbsp;<%= link_to 'Next page &raquo;', { :sort => params[:sort], :page =>
@page_pages.current.next } if @page_pages.current.next %>
      </div>
    </div>
  </th>
</tr>
<% end %>

```

The browser renders it anyway

It looks fine.

Until you have to understand what's underneath.

We're rendering it anyway

It looks fine. It reads fine.

Until the words stop sounding like your own.

Don't start by polishing it

Ask whether it should exist first.

chore: tighten comment prose for economy of language

I wrote this. 

I was going to say:

You can't tighten a sentence.

But you can feel it

Tighten?

Maybe if we were still setting hot type.

Shorten? Trim? Condense? Simplify? Hmm...

Tighten isn't wrong

The question isn't whether I wrote it.

It's whether I chose it.

There are no banned words

There are words we didn't choose.

Cookies

Some words are ours to choose.

Some aren't.

[Vitaly Friedman](#) / AUG 13, 2026 / [0 comments](#)

New EU Guidelines For AI Labelling

 7 min read

 [AI](#), [Design](#), [UX](#), [Business](#)

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QUICK SUMMARY ↔ *New EU guidelines, why AI sparkles aren't enough, when AI labels are required, and what the rules mean for AI-powered features and products. Brought to you by [Design Patterns For AI Interfaces](#), **friendly video courses on UX** and design patterns by Vitaly.*

There's been a lot of confusion and panic this week about "huge fines", "drastic measures" and "[sweeping new AI rules](#)" in the EU. In reality, it's a lot more narrow — and a lot more sensible. And mostly it's about making AI more obvious when it actually needs to be obvious — especially for AI-generated content.



ABOUT THE AUTHOR

Vitaly Friedman loves beautiful content and does
writ
[end.](#)

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compass/crawler-google-places

Extract data from thousands of Google Maps locations and businesses, including reviews,...



Compass

237K 4.7



Instagram Scraper

apify/instagram-scraper

Scrape and download Instagram posts, profiles, places, hashtags, photos, and comments. Get...



Apify

162K 4.7



Amazon Scraper

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Facebook Posts Scraper

apify/facebook-posts-scraper

Extract data from hundreds of Facebook posts

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clockworks/tiktok-scraper

Extract data from TikTok videos, hashtags, and users. Use URLs or search queries to scrape TikTok profiles, hashtags,...

 Clockworks

☆ 4.8 (371) 👤 290K



Google Maps Scraper

compass/crawler-google-places

Extract data from thousands of Google Maps locations and businesses, including reviews, reviewer details, images,...

 Compass

☆ 4.7 (1,817) 👤 612K



Instagram Scraper

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Extract Instagram posts, reels, profiles, places, hashtags, carousels, and comments. Get data from Instagram using...

 Apify

☆ 4.7 (595) 👤 400K



Website Content Crawler

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☆ 4.6 (233) 👤 159K



E-commerce Scraping Tool

apify/e-commerce-scraping-tool

Scrape data from e-commerce websites with E-commerce Scraping Tool. Scrape almost any retail site in minutes,...

 Apify

☆ 4.7 (50) 👤 15K



Facebook Posts Scraper

apify/facebook-posts-scraper

Extract posts, videos, and engagement metrics from Facebook pages. Get text captions, reactions, video...

 Apify

☆ 4.6 (233) 👤 111K

Which choices were actually ours?

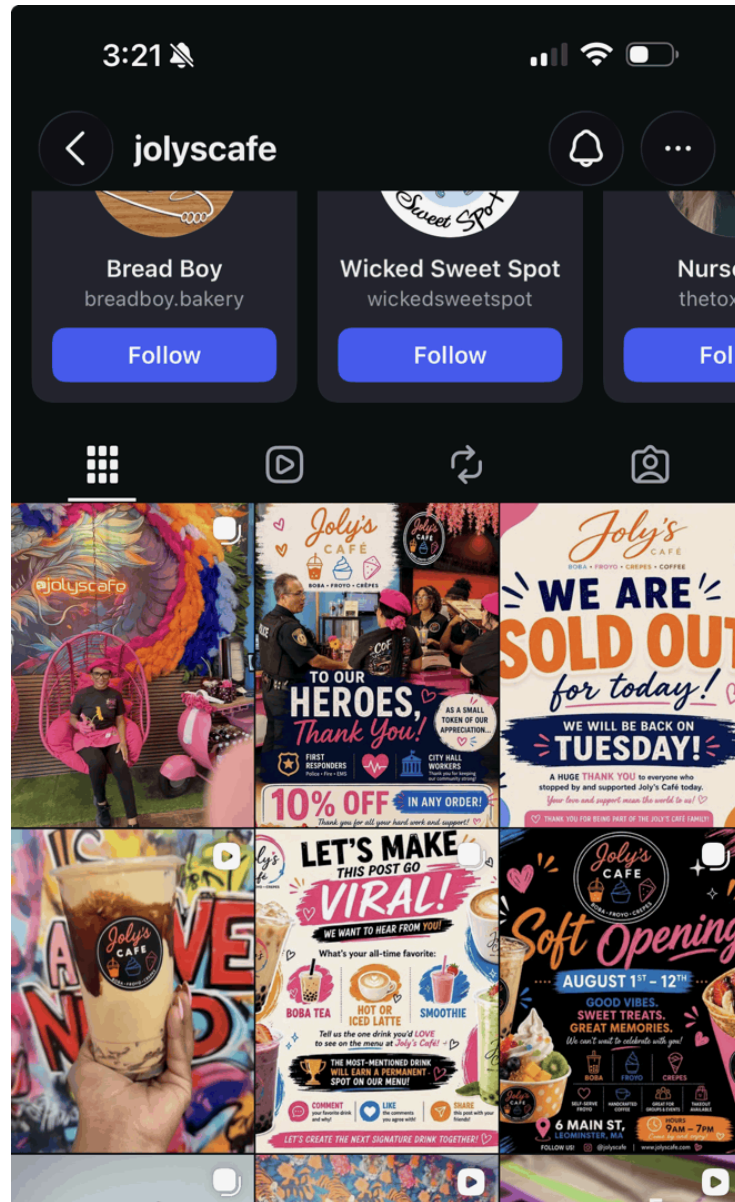
Constraints still leave choices.

Know which constraints you're responding to.

Content-first is still the right approach

The problem used to be getting content in early enough.

Now copy can arrive before the content exists.



A friend sent me this café's Instagram feed.



On Fire by KC Green, 2013. [GIF via GIPHY](#)

Good enough

Maybe the problem isn't that it looks bad.

It's that it looks done.

The laser printer made bad design look done

The model makes bad copy look done.

The quality isn't in the output.

It's in the judgment that produced it.

We've been asking whether we chose the words

There's a bigger question.

Did we have something to say before we started writing?

Before you write

1. **Reporter** finds something out.
2. **Editor** decides what matters.
3. **Writer** makes it understandable.

AI writing

We skipped to the writer.

We gave everyone a writer

Nobody automatically became a reporter.

Writing is thinking

(Not my words.)

The designer must think first, work later.

— Ladislav Sutnar, *Visual Design in Action*, 1961 ([quoted in Eye](#))



I use words as material.

— Nicole Fenton, *Words as Material*, 2015

Used too early, it collapses uncertainty before ideas have earned their shape. Used a bit later, it becomes a powerful partner, reacting to intent instead of defining it.

— José Torre, *A Sharp Tool Can Still Ruin the Cut*, DOC, 2025

Polishing

Almost done thinking...

Your word here



Turn rough ideas into polished work.

— *Claude App Store description, Anthropic, 2026*

You are out of free messages until 3:00 PM

Have lunch.

Go for a walk.

Keep thinking.

Writing needs somewhere to be unfinished

Scratchpad. Clipboard. Notes. Another file.

Cut it. Move it. Keep it.

Don't delete it just because it isn't right *here*.

Linting

Vale is a prose linter. It flags things worth another look.

It's a diagnostic, not a decision.

You still have to choose.

Some rules we built

- **MixedRegister**: formal and informal in the same string
- **PerformativeEmotion**: "we're excited to announce"
- **RoboticPhrases**: "delve into," "leverage," "streamline"

Every step widened access

Movable type → desktop publishing → the web → AI

Access to the tools isn't the same as judgment.

Reporter. Editor. Writer

The tool can support all three.

It can also make it easier to skip all three.

Copy that

- The words we inherit
- The words we're given
- The words the model gives back

Question that

- Where did it come from?
- What does it mean here?
- Did I choose it?

Edit that

Keep it. Change it. Cut it.

Choose.

The words don't have to be yours.

The choice does.

Dziękuję, dzięki, thanks 🍰

Copy that, words we didn't choose
Justin Gagne

- Slides: github.com/jgagne/copy-that
- linkedin.com/in/justingagne